

and the team struggled to complete the alpha by April. That represented an improvement over the past system because issues could be brought to the surface two months earlier than under the old way, but it did not produce the dramatically better results Greg was looking for.

In fact, over the course of the year, the team's process kept looking more and more like it had in prior years. As Greg put it, "Organizations have muscle memory," and it is hard for people to unlearn old habits. Greg was running up against a system, and making individual changes such as arbitrarily changing the release date were no match for it.

Year Three: Explosion

Frustrated by the limited progress in the previous year, Greg teamed up with the product development leader Himanshu Baxi. Together they tossed out all the old processes. They made a public declaration that their combined teams would be creating new processes and that they were not going to go back to the old way.

Instead of focusing on new deadlines, Greg and Himanshu invested in process, product, and technology changes that enabled working in smaller batches. Those technical innovations helped them get the desktop product to customers faster for feedback. Instead of building a comprehensive road map at the beginning of the year, Greg kicked off the year with what they called idea/code/solution jams that brought engineers, product managers, and customers together to create a pipeline of ideas. It was scary for Greg as a product manager to start the year without a defined list of what would be in the product release, but he had confidence in his team and the new process.

There were three differences in year three:

- Teams were involved in creating new technologies, processes, and systems.
- Cross-functional teams were formed around new great ideas.